Chapter 8 – The Gupta Empire

In the 4th century CE, a new ruler arose with a rather familiar name: Chandragupta. Like his namesake from centuries gone by, Chandragupta I was the first emperor of his dynasty and the leader of an empire that would flourish for more than 200 years. At the height of its reach, the Gupta Empire encompassed nearly all of modern northeast India, from Punjab to Kamarupa.

Like their ancestors, the Gupta rulers annexed the bulk of their empire through warfare; however, the vast region under their control enjoyed relative peace and security. Under the Guptas, this section of India underwent a golden age during which the arts once more came to the forefront of civilian life. Though the rulers were Hindu themselves, they were tolerant of followers of Buddhism and Jainism. Nevertheless, the Gupta Empire was a nation of more than one culture, though all those encompassed within it are classically considered Indian. There were the original Indus Valley people, the Aryans, and families with Greek or Chinese heritage living together under the shelter of the Himalayas. In such conditions, scholarly pursuit thrived.

A Buddhist university was established at Nalanda, in the northeastern part of the country near the very mountains where Buddhist temples dot the valleys between peaks even now. The school stood as a proud reminder of India’s Buddhist roots, even in the wake of the violent and singular Shunga Dynasty. Nalanda attracted intellects from near and far, both within the Gupta Empire and from Tibet, Nepal, China, Korea, and other Asian civilizations who wanted to study a specialized form of Buddhism: Mahayana. This particular school of Buddhism is probably purely Indian in its origins since it is usually believed to have been conceived within India.

Buddhists who follow the Mahayana path seek enlightenment specifically for the betterment of all beings. The writings of Mahayana Buddhists insist that the ultimate goal of reaching total enlightenment can be achieved within one lifetime (Buddhists believe in the possibility of more than one lifetime) and by anyone who commits to living according to Dhamma.

Now, I, Vairocana Buddha